

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Western Moral Philosophers and Thinkers - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Western Moral Philosophers and Thinkers

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

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Western ethical reasoning: four lenses and source discipline

2

Socrates and Plato: examination, knowledge, justice and wise rule

3

Aristotle: flourishing, habituated virtue, the mean and practical wisdom

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Kant: good will, duty and the Categorical Imperative

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Kant's 2024 quotation: legal guilt, ethical intention and provenance

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Bentham and Mill: utility, pleasures and act-rule distinctions

7

Mill's harm principle: liberty, coercion and majority power

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Rawls: original position, lexical priority and justice as fairness

9

Comparative institutional ethics and Indian administrative applications

10

Routed quotations, answer architecture and contemporary AI governance

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Generation: learner-v2:g1 **PYQ ownership:** Questions labelled as official reproduce the locally held UPSC GS-IV papers; routed historical demands are explicitly neutral renderings rather than invented quotations.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

A district magistrate initially blames low vaccination uptake on community ignorance, then tests that assumption through field consultations and discovers that irregular clinic timings are the main cause. Which ethical method best describes this revision? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Socratic examination requires an official to surface assumptions, ask for reasons, test contradictions and seek counter-views before exercising discretion; it is an anti-bias discipline rather than private introspection alone.
- B. Socratic intellectualism treats knowledge of the good as a necessary condition of virtue and connects wrongdoing with ignorance, while disciplined training and character safeguards remain necessary for public administration.
- C. Plato defines justice as ordered harmony: reason governs spirit and appetite within the person, while each institutional part performs its proper function without usurping another's role.
- D. Plato's philosopher-ruler represents knowledgeable and public-spirited rule, but it cannot be equated with modern technocracy or merit recruitment without adding constitutional accountability, participation and checks on elite power.

Answer: A

Explanation: Socratic examination converts introspection into reason-giving is the controlling principle. Socratic examination requires an official to surface assumptions, ask for reasons, test contradictions and seek counter-views before exercising discretion; it is an anti-bias discipline rather than private introspection alone. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

A selection-board chair records the assumptions behind an interview score, asks another member to challenge them and revises the score when the reasons prove inconsistent. Which Western thinker supplies the controlling method? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Plato defines justice as ordered harmony: reason governs spirit and appetite within the person, while each institutional part performs its proper function without usurping another's role.
- B. Socratic examination requires an official to surface assumptions, ask for reasons, test contradictions and seek counter-views before exercising discretion; it is an anti-bias discipline rather than private introspection alone.
- C. Plato's philosopher-ruler represents knowledgeable and public-spirited rule, but it cannot be equated with modern technocracy or merit recruitment without adding constitutional accountability, participation and checks on elite power.
- D. Socratic intellectualism treats knowledge of the good as a necessary condition of virtue and connects wrongdoing with ignorance, while disciplined training and character safeguards remain necessary for public administration.

Answer: B

Explanation: Socratic examination converts introspection into reason-giving is the controlling principle. Socratic examination requires an official to surface assumptions, ask for reasons, test contradictions and seek counter-views before exercising discretion; it is an anti-bias discipline rather than private introspection alone. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

An ethics academy teaches procurement officers how hidden conflicts of interest distort judgment, arguing that recognising the ethical wrong is necessary before conduct can improve. Which Socratic proposition underlies the programme? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Socratic examination requires an official to surface assumptions, ask for reasons, test contradictions and seek counter-views before exercising discretion; it is an anti-bias discipline rather than private introspection alone.
- B. Plato defines justice as ordered harmony: reason governs spirit and appetite within the person, while each institutional part performs its proper function without usurping another's role.
- C. Socratic intellectualism treats knowledge of the good as a necessary condition of virtue and connects wrongdoing with ignorance, while disciplined training and character safeguards remain necessary for public administration.
- D. Plato's philosopher-ruler represents knowledgeable and public-spirited rule, but it cannot be equated with modern technocracy or merit recruitment without adding constitutional accountability, participation and checks on elite power.

Answer: C

Explanation: Socratic intellectualism links virtue with knowledge of the good is the controlling principle. Socratic intellectualism treats knowledge of the good as a necessary condition of virtue and connects wrongdoing with ignorance, while disciplined training and character safeguards remain necessary for public administration. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

A department assumes that merely circulating conduct rules will make every employee virtuous, despite incentives encouraging concealment. Which limitation must qualify a simplistic use of Socratic intellectualism? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Plato defines justice as ordered harmony: reason governs spirit and appetite within the person, while each institutional part performs its proper function without usurping another's role.
- B. Plato's philosopher-ruler represents knowledgeable and public-spirited rule, but it cannot be equated with modern technocracy or merit recruitment without adding constitutional accountability, participation and checks on elite power.
- C. Socratic examination requires an official to surface assumptions, ask for reasons, test contradictions and seek counter-views before exercising discretion; it is an anti-bias discipline rather than private introspection alone.
- D. Socratic intellectualism treats knowledge of the good as a necessary condition of virtue and connects wrongdoing with ignorance, while disciplined training and character safeguards remain necessary for public administration.

Answer: D

Explanation: Socratic intellectualism links virtue with knowledge of the good is the controlling principle. Socratic intellectualism treats knowledge of the good as a necessary condition of virtue and connects wrongdoing with ignorance, while disciplined training and character safeguards remain necessary for public administration. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

A regulator separates investigation, adjudication and appellate review so that one unit cannot dominate the entire process. Which Platonic conception of justice provides the closest structural analogy? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Plato defines justice as ordered harmony: reason governs spirit and appetite within the person, while each institutional part performs its proper function without usurping another's role.
- B. Socratic examination requires an official to surface assumptions, ask for reasons, test contradictions and seek counter-views before exercising discretion; it is an anti-bias discipline rather than private introspection alone.
- C. Socratic intellectualism treats knowledge of the good as a necessary condition of virtue and connects wrongdoing with ignorance, while disciplined training and character safeguards remain necessary for public administration.
- D. Plato's philosopher-ruler represents knowledgeable and public-spirited rule, but it cannot be equated with modern technocracy or merit recruitment without adding constitutional accountability, participation and checks on elite power.

Answer: A

Explanation: Platonic justice is harmony in soul and institution is the controlling principle. Plato defines justice as ordered harmony: reason governs spirit and appetite within the person, while each institutional part performs its proper function without usurping another's role. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

A senior officer lets political ambition and personal appetite override evidence and constitutional duty. In Plato's tripartite model, which failure of inner order does this illustrate? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Socratic intellectualism treats knowledge of the good as a necessary condition of virtue and connects wrongdoing with ignorance, while disciplined training and character safeguards remain necessary for public administration.
- B. Plato defines justice as ordered harmony: reason governs spirit and appetite within the person, while each institutional part performs its proper function without usurping another's role.
- C. Plato's philosopher-ruler represents knowledgeable and public-spirited rule, but it cannot be equated with modern technocracy or merit recruitment without adding constitutional accountability, participation and checks on elite power.
- D. Socratic examination requires an official to surface assumptions, ask for reasons, test contradictions and seek counter-views before exercising discretion; it is an anti-bias discipline rather than private introspection alone.

Answer: B

Explanation: Platonic justice is harmony in soul and institution is the controlling principle. Plato defines justice as ordered harmony: reason governs spirit and appetite within the person, while each institutional part performs its proper function without usurping another's role. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

A state proposes allowing technical experts to make binding environmental decisions without public hearings or judicial review because expertise alone guarantees wisdom. Which caution about Plato is decisive? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Socratic examination requires an official to surface assumptions, ask for reasons, test contradictions and seek counter-views before exercising discretion; it is an anti-bias discipline rather than private introspection alone.
- B. Socratic intellectualism treats knowledge of the good as a necessary condition of virtue and connects wrongdoing with ignorance, while disciplined training and character safeguards remain necessary for public administration.
- C. Plato's philosopher-ruler represents knowledgeable and public-spirited rule, but it cannot be equated with modern technocracy or merit recruitment without adding constitutional accountability, participation and checks on elite power.
- D. Plato defines justice as ordered harmony: reason governs spirit and appetite within the person, while each institutional part performs its proper function without usurping another's role.

Answer: C

Explanation: The philosopher-ruler analogy requires democratic qualification is the controlling principle. Plato's philosopher-ruler represents knowledgeable and public-spirited rule, but it cannot be equated with modern technocracy or merit recruitment without adding constitutional accountability, participation and checks on elite power. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

A public-service commission combines specialist competence with transparent selection, legislative standards and judicial review. Which qualified use of Plato's philosopher-ruler ideal does this illustrate? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Socratic intellectualism treats knowledge of the good as a necessary condition of virtue and connects wrongdoing with ignorance, while disciplined training and character safeguards remain necessary for public administration.
- B. Plato defines justice as ordered harmony: reason governs spirit and appetite within the person, while each institutional part performs its proper function without usurping another's role.
- C. Socratic examination requires an official to surface assumptions, ask for reasons, test contradictions and seek counter-views before exercising discretion; it is an anti-bias discipline rather than private introspection alone.
- D. Plato's philosopher-ruler represents knowledgeable and public-spirited rule, but it cannot be equated with modern technocracy or merit recruitment without adding constitutional accountability, participation and checks on elite power.

Answer: D

Explanation: The philosopher-ruler analogy requires democratic qualification is the controlling principle. Plato's philosopher-ruler represents knowledgeable and public-spirited rule, but it cannot be equated with modern technocracy or merit recruitment without adding constitutional accountability, participation and checks on elite power. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

An officer rejects a lucrative but ethically compromised posting and chooses a career marked by integrity, public service and sustained excellence. Which Aristotelian end best evaluates the life as a whole? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Aristotle's eudaimonia means flourishing across a complete life through rational virtuous activity; it is not a passing feeling of happiness, pleasure or satisfaction produced by one successful decision.
- B. For Aristotle, moral virtue is a stable disposition formed through repeated right action and appropriate feeling; isolated good deeds or theoretical knowledge alone do not create a virtuous administrator.
- C. Aristotle's Golden Mean lies between excess and deficiency relative to the circumstances and agent; it is not a mathematical midpoint, and intrinsically wrong acts do not become virtuous through moderation.
- D. Aristotelian phronesis is the trained capacity to identify the appropriate virtue and proportion in a particular case, but administrative judgment must remain bounded by law, evidence and review.

Answer: A

Explanation: Eudaimonia is whole-life flourishing rather than transient pleasure is the controlling principle.

Aristotle's eudaimonia means flourishing across a complete life through rational virtuous activity; it is not a passing feeling of happiness, pleasure or satisfaction produced by one successful decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

A department equates employee well-being exclusively with short-term bonuses and entertainment events while ignoring meaningful work and character. Which Aristotelian distinction exposes the mistake? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Aristotle's Golden Mean lies between excess and deficiency relative to the circumstances and agent; it is not a mathematical midpoint, and intrinsically wrong acts do not become virtuous through moderation.
- B. Aristotle's eudaimonia means flourishing across a complete life through rational virtuous activity; it is not a passing feeling of happiness, pleasure or satisfaction produced by one successful decision.
- C. Aristotelian phronesis is the trained capacity to identify the appropriate virtue and proportion in a particular case, but administrative judgment must remain bounded by law, evidence and review.
- D. For Aristotle, moral virtue is a stable disposition formed through repeated right action and appropriate feeling; isolated good deeds or theoretical knowledge alone do not create a virtuous administrator.

Answer: B

Explanation: Eudaimonia is whole-life flourishing rather than transient pleasure is the controlling principle.

Aristotle's eudaimonia means flourishing across a complete life through rational virtuous activity; it is not a passing feeling of happiness, pleasure or satisfaction produced by one successful decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

A probation programme repeatedly places trainees in supervised citizen-hearing situations so that patience, fairness and courage become reliable habits. Which Aristotelian mechanism explains the design? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Aristotle's eudaimonia means flourishing across a complete life through rational virtuous activity; it is not a passing feeling of happiness, pleasure or satisfaction produced by one successful decision.
- B. Aristotle's Golden Mean lies between excess and deficiency relative to the circumstances and agent; it is not a mathematical midpoint, and intrinsically wrong acts do not become virtuous through moderation.
- C. For Aristotle, moral virtue is a stable disposition formed through repeated right action and appropriate feeling; isolated good deeds or theoretical knowledge alone do not create a virtuous administrator.
- D. Aristotelian phronesis is the trained capacity to identify the appropriate virtue and proportion in a particular case, but administrative judgment must remain bounded by law, evidence and review.

Answer: C

Explanation: Virtue is a disposition built by habituated action is the controlling principle. For Aristotle, moral virtue is a stable disposition formed through repeated right action and appropriate feeling; isolated good deeds or theoretical knowledge alone do not create a virtuous administrator. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

An officer makes one conspicuous charitable donation but routinely humiliates beneficiaries. Why would Aristotle refuse to infer the virtue of generosity from the isolated act? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Aristotle's Golden Mean lies between excess and deficiency relative to the circumstances and agent; it is not a mathematical midpoint, and intrinsically wrong acts do not become virtuous through moderation.
- B. Aristotelian phronesis is the trained capacity to identify the appropriate virtue and proportion in a particular case, but administrative judgment must remain bounded by law, evidence and review.
- C. Aristotle's eudaimonia means flourishing across a complete life through rational virtuous activity; it is not a passing feeling of happiness, pleasure or satisfaction produced by one successful decision.
- D. For Aristotle, moral virtue is a stable disposition formed through repeated right action and appropriate feeling; isolated good deeds or theoretical knowledge alone do not create a virtuous administrator.

Answer: D

Explanation: Virtue is a disposition built by habituated action is the controlling principle. For Aristotle, moral virtue is a stable disposition formed through repeated right action and appropriate feeling; isolated good deeds or theoretical knowledge alone do not create a virtuous administrator. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

During a tense procession, a district magistrate rejects both indiscriminate force and complete inaction, selecting targeted restrictions proportionate to verified risks. Which Aristotelian doctrine structures the judgment? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Aristotle's Golden Mean lies between excess and deficiency relative to the circumstances and agent; it is not a mathematical midpoint, and intrinsically wrong acts do not become virtuous through moderation.
- B. Aristotle's eudaimonia means flourishing across a complete life through rational virtuous activity; it is not a passing feeling of happiness, pleasure or satisfaction produced by one successful decision.
- C. For Aristotle, moral virtue is a stable disposition formed through repeated right action and appropriate feeling; isolated good deeds or theoretical knowledge alone do not create a virtuous administrator.
- D. Aristotelian phronesis is the trained capacity to identify the appropriate virtue and proportion in a particular case, but administrative judgment must remain bounded by law, evidence and review.

Answer: A

Explanation: The Golden Mean is context-relative proportion, not arithmetic compromise is the controlling principle. Aristotle's Golden Mean lies between excess and deficiency relative to the circumstances and agent; it is not a mathematical midpoint, and intrinsically wrong acts do not become virtuous through moderation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

An official argues that accepting a smaller bribe is the virtuous mean between taking a large bribe and refusing all payment. Which feature of Aristotle's doctrine makes this reasoning invalid? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. For Aristotle, moral virtue is a stable disposition formed through repeated right action and appropriate feeling; isolated good deeds or theoretical knowledge alone do not create a virtuous administrator.
- B. Aristotle's Golden Mean lies between excess and deficiency relative to the circumstances and agent; it is not a mathematical midpoint, and intrinsically wrong acts do not become virtuous through moderation.
- C. Aristotelian phronesis is the trained capacity to identify the appropriate virtue and proportion in a particular case, but administrative judgment must remain bounded by law, evidence and review.
- D. Aristotle's eudaimonia means flourishing across a complete life through rational virtuous activity; it is not a passing feeling of happiness, pleasure or satisfaction produced by one successful decision.

Answer: B

Explanation: The Golden Mean is context-relative proportion, not arithmetic compromise is the controlling principle. Aristotle's Golden Mean lies between excess and deficiency relative to the circumstances and agent; it is not a mathematical midpoint, and intrinsically wrong acts do not become virtuous through moderation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

Flood-relief rules do not anticipate a marooned migrant settlement. The collector uses evidence, humane judgment and recorded reasons to adapt delivery without abandoning legal safeguards. Which capacity is being exercised? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Aristotle's eudaimonia means flourishing across a complete life through rational virtuous activity; it is not a passing feeling of happiness, pleasure or satisfaction produced by one successful decision.
- B. For Aristotle, moral virtue is a stable disposition formed through repeated right action and appropriate feeling; isolated good deeds or theoretical knowledge alone do not create a virtuous administrator.
- C. Aristotelian phronesis is the trained capacity to identify the appropriate virtue and proportion in a particular case, but administrative judgment must remain bounded by law, evidence and review.
- D. Aristotle's Golden Mean lies between excess and deficiency relative to the circumstances and agent; it is not a mathematical midpoint, and intrinsically wrong acts do not become virtuous through moderation.

Answer: C

Explanation: Phronesis supplies context-sensitive practical wisdom is the controlling principle. Aristotelian phronesis is the trained capacity to identify the appropriate virtue and proportion in a particular case, but administrative judgment must remain bounded by law, evidence and review. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

Two officers invoke personal wisdom to reach opposite decisions without evidence or recorded reasons. Which institutional qualification prevents phronesis from becoming arbitrary discretion? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. For Aristotle, moral virtue is a stable disposition formed through repeated right action and appropriate feeling; isolated good deeds or theoretical knowledge alone do not create a virtuous administrator.
- B. Aristotle's Golden Mean lies between excess and deficiency relative to the circumstances and agent; it is not a mathematical midpoint, and intrinsically wrong acts do not become virtuous through moderation.
- C. Aristotle's eudaimonia means flourishing across a complete life through rational virtuous activity; it is not a passing feeling of happiness, pleasure or satisfaction produced by one successful decision.
- D. Aristotelian phronesis is the trained capacity to identify the appropriate virtue and proportion in a particular case, but administrative judgment must remain bounded by law, evidence and review.

Answer: D

Explanation: Phronesis supplies context-sensitive practical wisdom is the controlling principle. Aristotelian phronesis is the trained capacity to identify the appropriate virtue and proportion in a particular case, but administrative judgment must remain bounded by law, evidence and review. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

A procurement officer refuses a bribe solely because surveillance cameras are present, while intending to accept one later. Which Kantian distinction explains why outward compliance is ethically insufficient? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kant distinguishes acting from duty from merely conforming to duty: outwardly correct conduct lacks full moral worth when motivated only by advantage, fear of detection or expected praise.
- B. Kant's universal-law formulation asks whether the maxim underlying an act could be consistently willed as a rule for everyone, exposing self-serving exceptions invented for personal convenience.
- C. Kant's humanity formulation requires treating every person as an end with rational agency, prohibiting officials from using citizens merely as instruments for targets, revenue, publicity or political advantage.
- D. The 2024 Kant quotation contrasts external legal violation with ethical appraisal of a harboured wrongful intention; it must not be converted into punishment for involuntary or passing thoughts.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Moral worth depends on acting from duty** is the controlling principle. Kant distinguishes acting from duty from merely conforming to duty: outwardly correct conduct lacks full moral worth when motivated only by advantage, fear of detection or expected praise. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

A civil servant discloses an error despite certain reputational loss because truthfulness is owed to citizens. Which feature gives the act Kantian moral worth? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kant's humanity formulation requires treating every person as an end with rational agency, prohibiting officials from using citizens merely as instruments for targets, revenue, publicity or political advantage.
- B. Kant distinguishes acting from duty from merely conforming to duty: outwardly correct conduct lacks full moral worth when motivated only by advantage, fear of detection or expected praise.
- C. The 2024 Kant quotation contrasts external legal violation with ethical appraisal of a harboured wrongful intention; it must not be converted into punishment for involuntary or passing thoughts.
- D. Kant's universal-law formulation asks whether the maxim underlying an act could be consistently willed as a rule for everyone, exposing self-serving exceptions invented for personal convenience.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Moral worth depends on acting from duty** is the controlling principle. Kant distinguishes acting from duty from merely conforming to duty: outwardly correct conduct lacks full moral worth when motivated only by advantage, fear of detection or expected praise. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

An officer proposes concealing audit findings whenever disclosure may delay a social project. If every official followed that maxim, public audit would become self-defeating. Which Kantian test reveals the contradiction? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kant distinguishes acting from duty from merely conforming to duty: outwardly correct conduct lacks full moral worth when motivated only by advantage, fear of detection or expected praise.
- B. Kant's humanity formulation requires treating every person as an end with rational agency, prohibiting officials from using citizens merely as instruments for targets, revenue, publicity or political advantage.
- C. Kant's universal-law formulation asks whether the maxim underlying an act could be consistently willed as a rule for everyone, exposing self-serving exceptions invented for personal convenience.
- D. The 2024 Kant quotation contrasts external legal violation with ethical appraisal of a harboured wrongful intention; it must not be converted into punishment for involuntary or passing thoughts.

Answer: C

Explanation: Universalisability tests the consistency of an official's maxim is the controlling principle. Kant's universal-law formulation asks whether the maxim underlying an act could be consistently willed as a rule for everyone, exposing self-serving exceptions invented for personal convenience. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

A licensing official waives documentation only for relatives but could not will a universal rule permitting all officers the same favouritism. Which formulation directly condemns the exception? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kant's humanity formulation requires treating every person as an end with rational agency, prohibiting officials from using citizens merely as instruments for targets, revenue, publicity or political advantage.
- B. The 2024 Kant quotation contrasts external legal violation with ethical appraisal of a harboured wrongful intention; it must not be converted into punishment for involuntary or passing thoughts.
- C. Kant distinguishes acting from duty from merely conforming to duty: outwardly correct conduct lacks full moral worth when motivated only by advantage, fear of detection or expected praise.
- D. Kant's universal-law formulation asks whether the maxim underlying an act could be consistently willed as a rule for everyone, exposing self-serving exceptions invented for personal convenience.

Answer: D

Explanation: Universalisability tests the consistency of an official's maxim is the controlling principle. Kant's universal-law formulation asks whether the maxim underlying an act could be consistently willed as a rule for everyone, exposing self-serving exceptions invented for personal convenience. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

A district stages beneficiaries for a publicity event without informed consent and exposes their medical status to improve programme visibility. Which Kantian principle is most directly violated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kant's humanity formulation requires treating every person as an end with rational agency, prohibiting officials from using citizens merely as instruments for targets, revenue, publicity or political advantage.
- B. Kant distinguishes acting from duty from merely conforming to duty: outwardly correct conduct lacks full moral worth when motivated only by advantage, fear of detection or expected praise.
- C. Kant's universal-law formulation asks whether the maxim underlying an act could be consistently willed as a rule for everyone, exposing self-serving exceptions invented for personal convenience.
- D. The 2024 Kant quotation contrasts external legal violation with ethical appraisal of a harboured wrongful intention; it must not be converted into punishment for involuntary or passing thoughts.

Answer: A

Explanation: The humanity formula prohibits using citizens merely as means is the controlling principle. Kant's humanity formulation requires treating every person as an end with rational agency, prohibiting officials from using citizens merely as instruments for targets, revenue, publicity or political advantage. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

A rehabilitation plan gives displaced families complete information, meaningful consultation and real choice rather than treating compensation as purchase of compliance. Which Kantian requirement does it respect? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kant's universal-law formulation asks whether the maxim underlying an act could be consistently willed as a rule for everyone, exposing self-serving exceptions invented for personal convenience.
- B. Kant's humanity formulation requires treating every person as an end with rational agency, prohibiting officials from using citizens merely as instruments for targets, revenue, publicity or political advantage.
- C. The 2024 Kant quotation contrasts external legal violation with ethical appraisal of a harboured wrongful intention; it must not be converted into punishment for involuntary or passing thoughts.
- D. Kant distinguishes acting from duty from merely conforming to duty: outwardly correct conduct lacks full moral worth when motivated only by advantage, fear of detection or expected praise.

Answer: B

Explanation: The humanity formula prohibits using citizens merely as means is the controlling principle. Kant's humanity formulation requires treating every person as an end with rational agency, prohibiting officials from using citizens merely as instruments for targets, revenue, publicity or political advantage. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

An officer secretly resolves to favour a contractor but the tender is cancelled before any illegal award. Which distinction explains why criminal liability may be absent while ethical failure remains? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kant distinguishes acting from duty from merely conforming to duty: outwardly correct conduct lacks full moral worth when motivated only by advantage, fear of detection or expected praise.
- B. Kant's universal-law formulation asks whether the maxim underlying an act could be consistently willed as a rule for everyone, exposing self-serving exceptions invented for personal convenience.
- C. The 2024 Kant quotation contrasts external legal violation with ethical appraisal of a harboured wrongful intention; it must not be converted into punishment for involuntary or passing thoughts.
- D. Kant's humanity formulation requires treating every person as an end with rational agency, prohibiting officials from using citizens merely as instruments for targets, revenue, publicity or political advantage.

Answer: C

Explanation: Kantian ethical guilt concerns harboured intention and disposition is the controlling principle. The 2024 Kant quotation contrasts external legal violation with ethical appraisal of a harboured wrongful intention; it must not be converted into punishment for involuntary or passing thoughts. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

A public employee experiences an unwanted prejudiced thought, rejects it and acts impartially. Why would the careful reading of Kant's reconstructed lecture reject automatic ethical guilt? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kant's universal-law formulation asks whether the maxim underlying an act could be consistently willed as a rule for everyone, exposing self-serving exceptions invented for personal convenience.
- B. Kant's humanity formulation requires treating every person as an end with rational agency, prohibiting officials from using citizens merely as instruments for targets, revenue, publicity or political advantage.
- C. Kant distinguishes acting from duty from merely conforming to duty: outwardly correct conduct lacks full moral worth when motivated only by advantage, fear of detection or expected praise.
- D. The 2024 Kant quotation contrasts external legal violation with ethical appraisal of a harboured wrongful intention; it must not be converted into punishment for involuntary or passing thoughts.

Answer: D

Explanation: Kantian ethical guilt concerns harboured intention and disposition is the controlling principle. The 2024 Kant quotation contrasts external legal violation with ethical appraisal of a harboured wrongful intention; it must not be converted into punishment for involuntary or passing thoughts. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

A city compares a commercial entertainment project with a public-library network that yields fewer immediate visits but deeper educational and civic benefits. Which Millian refinement is relevant? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Utilitarianism evaluates acts and policies by their contribution to aggregate happiness or welfare, while Mill's distinction between higher and lower pleasures rejects a purely quantitative or majority-headcount calculus.
- B. Act utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of a particular act, whereas rule utilitarianism evaluates generally followed rules; treating Mill himself as exclusively a rule utilitarian remains a disputed interpretation.
- C. Mill permits coercion of a competent adult principally to prevent harm to others, not merely offence, moral dislike or paternalistic enforcement of majority preferences; the boundary of harm remains contestable.
- D. Rule-utilitarian support for stable rights and Mill's liberty principle constrain crude welfare maximisation, but they do not make every liberty-welfare conflict disappear or turn utilitarianism into deontology.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Millian utility includes qualitative differences among pleasures** is the controlling principle. Utilitarianism evaluates acts and policies by their contribution to aggregate happiness or welfare, while Mill's distinction between higher and lower pleasures rejects a purely quantitative or majority-headcount calculus. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

A welfare department counts only the number of beneficiaries reached and ignores the dignity, quality and durability of outcomes. Which limitation of a crude utility calculation does this reveal? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Mill permits coercion of a competent adult principally to prevent harm to others, not merely offence, moral dislike or paternalistic enforcement of majority preferences; the boundary of harm remains contestable.
- B. Utilitarianism evaluates acts and policies by their contribution to aggregate happiness or welfare, while Mill's distinction between higher and lower pleasures rejects a purely quantitative or majority-headcount calculus.
- C. Rule-utilitarian support for stable rights and Mill's liberty principle constrain crude welfare maximisation, but they do not make every liberty-welfare conflict disappear or turn utilitarianism into deontology.
- D. Act utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of a particular act, whereas rule utilitarianism evaluates generally followed rules; treating Mill himself as exclusively a rule utilitarian remains a disputed interpretation.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Millian utility includes qualitative differences among pleasures** is the controlling principle. Utilitarianism evaluates acts and policies by their contribution to aggregate happiness or welfare, while Mill's distinction between higher and lower pleasures rejects a purely quantitative or majority-headcount calculus. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

To calm a mob, an officer considers framing one innocent person, but then evaluates the long-run consequences of a general rule permitting such punishment. Which utilitarian variant performs the second test? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Utilitarianism evaluates acts and policies by their contribution to aggregate happiness or welfare, while Mill's distinction between higher and lower pleasures rejects a purely quantitative or majority-headcount calculus.
- B. Mill permits coercion of a competent adult principally to prevent harm to others, not merely offence, moral dislike or paternalistic enforcement of majority preferences; the boundary of harm remains contestable.
- C. Act utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of a particular act, whereas rule utilitarianism evaluates generally followed rules; treating Mill himself as exclusively a rule utilitarian remains a disputed interpretation.
- D. Rule-utilitarian support for stable rights and Mill's liberty principle constrain crude welfare maximisation, but they do not make every liberty-welfare conflict disappear or turn utilitarianism into deontology.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Act and rule utilitarianism evaluate different objects** is the controlling principle. Act utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of a particular act, whereas rule utilitarianism evaluates generally followed rules; treating Mill himself as exclusively a rule utilitarian remains a disputed interpretation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

A student states without qualification that Mill invented and unequivocally endorsed modern rule utilitarianism. Which historical caution should correct the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Mill permits coercion of a competent adult principally to prevent harm to others, not merely offence, moral dislike or paternalistic enforcement of majority preferences; the boundary of harm remains contestable.
- B. Rule-utilitarian support for stable rights and Mill's liberty principle constrain crude welfare maximisation, but they do not make every liberty-welfare conflict disappear or turn utilitarianism into deontology.
- C. Utilitarianism evaluates acts and policies by their contribution to aggregate happiness or welfare, while Mill's distinction between higher and lower pleasures rejects a purely quantitative or majority-headcount calculus.
- D. Act utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of a particular act, whereas rule utilitarianism evaluates generally followed rules; treating Mill himself as exclusively a rule utilitarian remains a disputed interpretation.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Act and rule utilitarianism evaluate different objects** is the controlling principle. Act utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of a particular act, whereas rule utilitarianism evaluates generally followed rules; treating Mill himself as exclusively a rule utilitarian remains a disputed interpretation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

A municipality bans an unconventional peaceful performance solely because many residents find it offensive, although no demonstrable injury is shown. Which Millian distinction weighs against the ban? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Mill permits coercion of a competent adult principally to prevent harm to others, not merely offence, moral dislike or paternalistic enforcement of majority preferences; the boundary of harm remains contestable.
- B. Utilitarianism evaluates acts and policies by their contribution to aggregate happiness or welfare, while Mill's distinction between higher and lower pleasures rejects a purely quantitative or majority-headcount calculus.
- C. Act utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of a particular act, whereas rule utilitarianism evaluates generally followed rules; treating Mill himself as exclusively a rule utilitarian remains a disputed interpretation.
- D. Rule-utilitarian support for stable rights and Mill's liberty principle constrain crude welfare maximisation, but they do not make every liberty-welfare conflict disappear or turn utilitarianism into deontology.

Answer: A

Explanation: The harm principle creates a presumption against coercion is the controlling principle. Mill permits coercion of a competent adult principally to prevent harm to others, not merely offence, moral dislike or paternalistic enforcement of majority preferences; the boundary of harm remains contestable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

A factory's private operating choices contaminate a village water source. Which side of Mill's self-regarding and other-regarding distinction justifies state intervention? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Act utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of a particular act, whereas rule utilitarianism evaluates generally followed rules; treating Mill himself as exclusively a rule utilitarian remains a disputed interpretation.
- B. Mill permits coercion of a competent adult principally to prevent harm to others, not merely offence, moral dislike or paternalistic enforcement of majority preferences; the boundary of harm remains contestable.
- C. Rule-utilitarian support for stable rights and Mill's liberty principle constrain crude welfare maximisation, but they do not make every liberty-welfare conflict disappear or turn utilitarianism into deontology.
- D. Utilitarianism evaluates acts and policies by their contribution to aggregate happiness or welfare, while Mill's distinction between higher and lower pleasures rejects a purely quantitative or majority-headcount calculus.

Answer: B

Explanation: The harm principle creates a presumption against coercion is the controlling principle. Mill permits coercion of a competent adult principally to prevent harm to others, not merely offence, moral dislike or paternalistic enforcement of majority preferences; the boundary of harm remains contestable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

A police chief defends due process because a stable rule against arbitrary arrest maximises long-run trust and security. Which theory justifies the rule through its consequences rather than inherent duty? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Utilitarianism evaluates acts and policies by their contribution to aggregate happiness or welfare, while Mill's distinction between higher and lower pleasures rejects a purely quantitative or majority-headcount calculus.
- B. Act utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of a particular act, whereas rule utilitarianism evaluates generally followed rules; treating Mill himself as exclusively a rule utilitarian remains a disputed interpretation.
- C. Rule-utilitarian support for stable rights and Mill's liberty principle constrain crude welfare maximisation, but they do not make every liberty-welfare conflict disappear or turn utilitarianism into deontology.
- D. Mill permits coercion of a competent adult principally to prevent harm to others, not merely offence, moral dislike or paternalistic enforcement of majority preferences; the boundary of harm remains contestable.

Answer: C

Explanation: Utilitarian rights safeguards remain consequential and contestable is the controlling principle. Rule-utilitarian support for stable rights and Mill's liberty principle constrain crude welfare maximisation, but they do not make every liberty-welfare conflict disappear or turn utilitarianism into deontology. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

A policymaker claims that calling a policy rule-utilitarian makes individual rights absolute and immune from future welfare calculations. Which conceptual limit invalidates the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Act utilitarianism evaluates the consequences of a particular act, whereas rule utilitarianism evaluates generally followed rules; treating Mill himself as exclusively a rule utilitarian remains a disputed interpretation.
- B. Mill permits coercion of a competent adult principally to prevent harm to others, not merely offence, moral dislike or paternalistic enforcement of majority preferences; the boundary of harm remains contestable.
- C. Utilitarianism evaluates acts and policies by their contribution to aggregate happiness or welfare, while Mill's distinction between higher and lower pleasures rejects a purely quantitative or majority-headcount calculus.
- D. Rule-utilitarian support for stable rights and Mill's liberty principle constrain crude welfare maximisation, but they do not make every liberty-welfare conflict disappear or turn utilitarianism into deontology.

Answer: D

Explanation: Utilitarian rights safeguards remain consequential and contestable is the controlling principle. Rule-utilitarian support for stable rights and Mill's liberty principle constrain crude welfare maximisation, but they do not make every liberty-welfare conflict disappear or turn utilitarianism into deontology. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

A committee designs disability-benefit access while imagining that any member could later be a remote, poor or disabled applicant. Which Rawlsian device guides the exercise? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rawls's original position is a device of representation in which parties choose principles without knowing morally arbitrary facts about their eventual class, talents, identity or conception of the good.
- B. Rawls gives equal basic liberties lexical priority over social and economic advantages; they cannot be reduced merely to secure higher income, administrative efficiency or greater aggregate welfare.
- C. Fair equality of opportunity requires genuinely accessible offices and prospects, not merely formal non-discrimination, and it takes priority within Rawls's second principle over the difference principle.
- D. Rawls permits social and economic inequality only when it benefits the least advantaged after liberty and fair opportunity are secured; the principle neither requires identical outcomes nor validates every transfer.

Answer: A

Explanation: The original position filters morally arbitrary advantage is the controlling principle. Rawls's original position is a device of representation in which parties choose principles without knowing morally arbitrary facts about their eventual class, talents, identity or conception of the good. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

An official rejects the veil of ignorance because policymakers cannot literally erase knowledge of their identities. Which distinction shows why this objection misunderstands Rawls? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Fair equality of opportunity requires genuinely accessible offices and prospects, not merely formal non-discrimination, and it takes priority within Rawls's second principle over the difference principle.
- B. Rawls's original position is a device of representation in which parties choose principles without knowing morally arbitrary facts about their eventual class, talents, identity or conception of the good.
- C. Rawls permits social and economic inequality only when it benefits the least advantaged after liberty and fair opportunity are secured; the principle neither requires identical outcomes nor validates every transfer.
- D. Rawls gives equal basic liberties lexical priority over social and economic advantages; they cannot be reduced merely to secure higher income, administrative efficiency or greater aggregate welfare.

Answer: B

Explanation: The original position filters morally arbitrary advantage is the controlling principle. Rawls's original position is a device of representation in which parties choose principles without knowing morally arbitrary facts about their eventual class, talents, identity or conception of the good. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

A government proposes suppressing peaceful criticism because investor confidence and tax revenue may rise. Which Rawlsian priority blocks trading a basic liberty for economic gain? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rawls's original position is a device of representation in which parties choose principles without knowing morally arbitrary facts about their eventual class, talents, identity or conception of the good.
- B. Fair equality of opportunity requires genuinely accessible offices and prospects, not merely formal non-discrimination, and it takes priority within Rawls's second principle over the difference principle.
- C. Rawls gives equal basic liberties lexical priority over social and economic advantages; they cannot be reduced merely to secure higher income, administrative efficiency or greater aggregate welfare.
- D. Rawls permits social and economic inequality only when it benefits the least advantaged after liberty and fair opportunity are secured; the principle neither requires identical outcomes nor validates every transfer.

Answer: C

Explanation: Equal basic liberties have lexical priority is the controlling principle. Rawls gives equal basic liberties lexical priority over social and economic advantages; they cannot be reduced merely to secure higher income, administrative efficiency or greater aggregate welfare. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

A welfare programme improves average income but conditions benefits on surrendering freedom of association. Which first step in Rawls's ordering has the programme failed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Fair equality of opportunity requires genuinely accessible offices and prospects, not merely formal non-discrimination, and it takes priority within Rawls's second principle over the difference principle.
- B. Rawls permits social and economic inequality only when it benefits the least advantaged after liberty and fair opportunity are secured; the principle neither requires identical outcomes nor validates every transfer.
- C. Rawls's original position is a device of representation in which parties choose principles without knowing morally arbitrary facts about their eventual class, talents, identity or conception of the good.
- D. Rawls gives equal basic liberties lexical priority over social and economic advantages; they cannot be reduced merely to secure higher income, administrative efficiency or greater aggregate welfare.

Answer: D

Explanation: Equal basic liberties have lexical priority is the controlling principle. Rawls gives equal basic liberties lexical priority over social and economic advantages; they cannot be reduced merely to secure higher income, administrative efficiency or greater aggregate welfare. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

A civil-service examination is formally open to all, but inaccessible centres and unavailable assistive technology exclude many disabled candidates. Which Rawlsian standard is unmet? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Fair equality of opportunity requires genuinely accessible offices and prospects, not merely formal non-discrimination, and it takes priority within Rawls's second principle over the difference principle.
- B. Rawls's original position is a device of representation in which parties choose principles without knowing morally arbitrary facts about their eventual class, talents, identity or conception of the good.
- C. Rawls gives equal basic liberties lexical priority over social and economic advantages; they cannot be reduced merely to secure higher income, administrative efficiency or greater aggregate welfare.
- D. Rawls permits social and economic inequality only when it benefits the least advantaged after liberty and fair opportunity are secured; the principle neither requires identical outcomes nor validates every transfer.

Answer: A

Explanation: Fair equality of opportunity precedes the difference principle is the controlling principle. Fair equality of opportunity requires genuinely accessible offices and prospects, not merely formal non-discrimination, and it takes priority within Rawls's second principle over the difference principle. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

A policy increases income for the poorest but reserves influential public offices for one hereditary group. Which lexical priority prevents invoking the difference principle as a defence? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rawls gives equal basic liberties lexical priority over social and economic advantages; they cannot be reduced merely to secure higher income, administrative efficiency or greater aggregate welfare.
- B. Fair equality of opportunity requires genuinely accessible offices and prospects, not merely formal non-discrimination, and it takes priority within Rawls's second principle over the difference principle.
- C. Rawls permits social and economic inequality only when it benefits the least advantaged after liberty and fair opportunity are secured; the principle neither requires identical outcomes nor validates every transfer.
- D. Rawls's original position is a device of representation in which parties choose principles without knowing morally arbitrary facts about their eventual class, talents, identity or conception of the good.

Answer: B

Explanation: Fair equality of opportunity precedes the difference principle is the controlling principle. Fair equality of opportunity requires genuinely accessible offices and prospects, not merely formal non-discrimination, and it takes priority within Rawls's second principle over the difference principle. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

A higher rural-service allowance attracts doctors to underserved districts and materially improves care for the worst-off. Which Rawlsian principle can justify the pay inequality? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rawls's original position is a device of representation in which parties choose principles without knowing morally arbitrary facts about their eventual class, talents, identity or conception of the good.
- B. Rawls gives equal basic liberties lexical priority over social and economic advantages; they cannot be reduced merely to secure higher income, administrative efficiency or greater aggregate welfare.
- C. Rawls permits social and economic inequality only when it benefits the least advantaged after liberty and fair opportunity are secured; the principle neither requires identical outcomes nor validates every transfer.
- D. Fair equality of opportunity requires genuinely accessible offices and prospects, not merely formal non-discrimination, and it takes priority within Rawls's second principle over the difference principle.

Answer: C

Explanation: The difference principle civilises rather than abolishes inequality is the controlling principle. Rawls permits social and economic inequality only when it benefits the least advantaged after liberty and fair opportunity are secured; the principle neither requires identical outcomes nor validates every transfer. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

A subsidy enriches an already privileged industry while offering only symbolic benefits to poor households. Which Rawlsian burden has not been discharged? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rawls gives equal basic liberties lexical priority over social and economic advantages; they cannot be reduced merely to secure higher income, administrative efficiency or greater aggregate welfare.
- B. Fair equality of opportunity requires genuinely accessible offices and prospects, not merely formal non-discrimination, and it takes priority within Rawls's second principle over the difference principle.
- C. Rawls's original position is a device of representation in which parties choose principles without knowing morally arbitrary facts about their eventual class, talents, identity or conception of the good.
- D. Rawls permits social and economic inequality only when it benefits the least advantaged after liberty and fair opportunity are secured; the principle neither requires identical outcomes nor validates every transfer.

Answer: D

Explanation: The difference principle civilises rather than abolishes inequality is the controlling principle. Rawls permits social and economic inequality only when it benefits the least advantaged after liberty and fair opportunity are secured; the principle neither requires identical outcomes nor validates every transfer. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

A dam proposal promises aggregate electricity benefits, displaces tribal families and uses a consultation process designed without vulnerable voices. Which multi-theory method gives the most complete evaluation? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kant tests maxims and respect, Mill tests consequences and harm, Aristotle tests character and proportion, while Rawls tests whether the underlying institution or distributive rule is fair.
- B. Codes of ethics may address motives, values and aspirations while codes of conduct regulate external acts, but this is an administrative analogy to Kant's ethical-legal distinction rather than a complete identity.
- C. UPSC-attributed Socrates, Dalai Lama, Erik Erikson, Potter Stewart and William James quotations should be interpreted for their ethical meaning while avoiding invented primary-text citations or exaggerated authenticity claims.
- D. Mapping People First to Kant, Fairness and Equity to Rawls, safety to Mill, proportionate governance to Aristotle and explainability to Socrates is an analytical inference, not an official classification.

Answer: A

Explanation: Four ethical lenses test different objects is the controlling principle. Kant tests maxims and respect, Mill tests consequences and harm, Aristotle tests character and proportion, while Rawls tests whether the underlying institution or distributive rule is fair. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

An answer applies only cost-benefit analysis to a forced-relocation case and never tests dignity, proportionality or institutional fairness. Which comparative architecture identifies the omissions? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. UPSC-attributed Socrates, Dalai Lama, Erik Erikson, Potter Stewart and William James quotations should be interpreted for their ethical meaning while avoiding invented primary-text citations or exaggerated authenticity claims.
- B. Kant tests maxims and respect, Mill tests consequences and harm, Aristotle tests character and proportion, while Rawls tests whether the underlying institution or distributive rule is fair.
- C. Mapping People First to Kant, Fairness and Equity to Rawls, safety to Mill, proportionate governance to Aristotle and explainability to Socrates is an analytical inference, not an official classification.
- D. Codes of ethics may address motives, values and aspirations while codes of conduct regulate external acts, but this is an administrative analogy to Kant's ethical-legal distinction rather than a complete identity.

Answer: B

Explanation: Four ethical lenses test different objects is the controlling principle. Kant tests maxims and respect, Mill tests consequences and harm, Aristotle tests character and proportion, while Rawls tests whether the underlying institution or distributive rule is fair. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

A department's conduct code prohibits gifts, while its ethics statement asks officials to cultivate impartial motives and public-service commitment. Which qualified Kantian analogy explains the two layers? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kant tests maxims and respect, Mill tests consequences and harm, Aristotle tests character and proportion, while Rawls tests whether the underlying institution or distributive rule is fair.
- B. UPSC-attributed Socrates, Dalai Lama, Erik Erikson, Potter Stewart and William James quotations should be interpreted for their ethical meaning while avoiding invented primary-text citations or exaggerated authenticity claims.
- C. Codes of ethics may address motives, values and aspirations while codes of conduct regulate external acts, but this is an administrative analogy to Kant's ethical-legal distinction rather than a complete identity.
- D. Mapping People First to Kant, Fairness and Equity to Rawls, safety to Mill, proportionate governance to Aristotle and explainability to Socrates is an analytical inference, not an official classification.

Answer: C

Explanation: Codes of ethics and conduct only partially mirror Kant's distinction is the controlling principle. Codes of ethics may address motives, values and aspirations while codes of conduct regulate external acts, but this is an administrative analogy to Kant's ethical-legal distinction rather than a complete identity. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

A trainee claims every code-of-conduct breach is legal guilt and every unworthy motive is formally punishable. Which limit of the ethics-conduct analogy corrects the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. UPSC-attributed Socrates, Dalai Lama, Erik Erikson, Potter Stewart and William James quotations should be interpreted for their ethical meaning while avoiding invented primary-text citations or exaggerated authenticity claims.
- B. Mapping People First to Kant, Fairness and Equity to Rawls, safety to Mill, proportionate governance to Aristotle and explainability to Socrates is an analytical inference, not an official classification.
- C. Kant tests maxims and respect, Mill tests consequences and harm, Aristotle tests character and proportion, while Rawls tests whether the underlying institution or distributive rule is fair.
- D. Codes of ethics may address motives, values and aspirations while codes of conduct regulate external acts, but this is an administrative analogy to Kant's ethical-legal distinction rather than a complete identity.

Answer: D

Explanation: Codes of ethics and conduct only partially mirror Kant's distinction is the controlling principle. Codes of ethics may address motives, values and aspirations while codes of conduct regulate external acts, but this is an administrative analogy to Kant's ethical-legal distinction rather than a complete identity. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

A candidate cannot trace an assigned quotation to the named thinker's published work but explains its ethical meaning and writes 'as attributed in the question.' Which scholarly discipline is being followed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. UPSC-attributed Socrates, Dalai Lama, Erik Erikson, Potter Stewart and William James quotations should be interpreted for their ethical meaning while avoiding invented primary-text citations or exaggerated authenticity claims.
- B. Kant tests maxims and respect, Mill tests consequences and harm, Aristotle tests character and proportion, while Rawls tests whether the underlying institution or distributive rule is fair.
- C. Codes of ethics may address motives, values and aspirations while codes of conduct regulate external acts, but this is an administrative analogy to Kant's ethical-legal distinction rather than a complete identity.
- D. Mapping People First to Kant, Fairness and Equity to Rawls, safety to Mill, proportionate governance to Aristotle and explainability to Socrates is an analytical inference, not an official classification.

Answer: A

Explanation: Paper-attributed quotations require explicit provenance discipline is the controlling principle. UPSC-attributed Socrates, Dalai Lama, Erik Erikson, Potter Stewart and William James quotations should be interpreted for their ethical meaning while avoiding invented primary-text citations or exaggerated authenticity claims. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

A model answer fabricates a book title and page number for the 2020 Socrates quotation to appear authoritative. Which source-handling rule has been violated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Codes of ethics may address motives, values and aspirations while codes of conduct regulate external acts, but this is an administrative analogy to Kant's ethical-legal distinction rather than a complete identity.
- B. UPSC-attributed Socrates, Dalai Lama, Erik Erikson, Potter Stewart and William James quotations should be interpreted for their ethical meaning while avoiding invented primary-text citations or exaggerated authenticity claims.
- C. Mapping People First to Kant, Fairness and Equity to Rawls, safety to Mill, proportionate governance to Aristotle and explainability to Socrates is an analytical inference, not an official classification.
- D. Kant tests maxims and respect, Mill tests consequences and harm, Aristotle tests character and proportion, while Rawls tests whether the underlying institution or distributive rule is fair.

Answer: B

Explanation: Paper-attributed quotations require explicit provenance discipline is the controlling principle. UPSC-attributed Socrates, Dalai Lama, Erik Erikson, Potter Stewart and William James quotations should be interpreted for their ethical meaning while avoiding invented primary-text citations or exaggerated authenticity claims. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

An officer uses the India AI Governance Guidelines to compare philosophical approaches but clearly labels every thinker-link as her own analytical mapping. Which evidence practice makes the use valid? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Kant tests maxims and respect, Mill tests consequences and harm, Aristotle tests character and proportion, while Rawls tests whether the underlying institution or distributive rule is fair.
- B. Codes of ethics may address motives, values and aspirations while codes of conduct regulate external acts, but this is an administrative analogy to Kant's ethical-legal distinction rather than a complete identity.
- C. Mapping People First to Kant, Fairness and Equity to Rawls, safety to Mill, proportionate governance to Aristotle and explainability to Socrates is an analytical inference, not an official classification.
- D. UPSC-attributed Socrates, Dalai Lama, Erik Erikson, Potter Stewart and William James quotations should be interpreted for their ethical meaning while avoiding invented primary-text citations or exaggerated authenticity claims.

Answer: C

Explanation: AI-governance philosopher mappings are analytical inferences is the controlling principle. Mapping People First to Kant, Fairness and Equity to Rawls, safety to Mill, proportionate governance to Aristotle and explainability to Socrates is an analytical inference, not an official classification. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

A presentation claims that MeitY officially classified its seven sutras under Kant, Mill, Rawls, Aristotle and Socrates. Which provenance correction is required? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Codes of ethics may address motives, values and aspirations while codes of conduct regulate external acts, but this is an administrative analogy to Kant's ethical-legal distinction rather than a complete identity.
- B. UPSC-attributed Socrates, Dalai Lama, Erik Erikson, Potter Stewart and William James quotations should be interpreted for their ethical meaning while avoiding invented primary-text citations or exaggerated authenticity claims.
- C. Kant tests maxims and respect, Mill tests consequences and harm, Aristotle tests character and proportion, while Rawls tests whether the underlying institution or distributive rule is fair.
- D. Mapping People First to Kant, Fairness and Equity to Rawls, safety to Mill, proportionate governance to Aristotle and explainability to Socrates is an analytical inference, not an official classification.

Answer: D

Explanation: AI-governance philosopher mappings are analytical inferences is the controlling principle. Mapping People First to Kant, Fairness and Equity to Rawls, safety to Mill, proportionate governance to Aristotle and explainability to Socrates is an analytical inference, not an official classification. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: With regard to morality of actions, one view is that means are of paramount importance and the other view is that the ends justify the means. Which view do you think is more appropriate? Justify your answer. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact official text: 2018 GS-IV Q4(b), local paper books/more_previous_papers/GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf. Primary routing is Topic 08; included here as a cross-owner Kant-Mill-Aristotle comparison. It is one isolated 10-mark, 150-word subpart.

Model solution

Neither a good end nor formally clean means alone completes moral evaluation, but constitutional public administration must give ethical and lawful means a non-negotiable priority. Kant explains why: a maxim permitting deception, coercion or discrimination cannot become moral merely because the expected outcome is beneficial, and citizens cannot be used merely as instruments for targets.

Consequences nevertheless matter when choosing among permissible means. A district administration selecting between two lawful vaccination strategies should prefer the one that protects more people with less disruption. Mill therefore improves practical choice without authorising every expedient. Aristotle adds *phronesis*: the official must judge proportion, context and the character expressed by the action.

Thus, the appropriate position is qualified means-priority: pursue legitimate public ends through lawful, truthful, proportionate and dignity-respecting means, then use consequences to select among those ethical options. Otherwise apparent success corrodes public trust and the legitimacy of the end itself.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: "The true rule, in determining to embrace, or reject any thing, is not whether it has any evil in it; but whether it has more evil than good...especially of governmental policy...our best judgment of the preponderance between them is continually demanded." - Abraham Lincoln. What does this quotation mean to you in the present context? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact official attribution and text: 2018 GS-IV Q6(a), local paper books/more_previous_papers/GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf. The routing ledger's 'attribution unclear in OCR' label is erroneous: the official English text clearly names Abraham Lincoln. This isolated subpart is 10 marks and 150 words.

Model solution

Lincoln's quotation recognises that public policy usually involves mixed consequences rather than choices between perfect good and pure evil. Ethical judgment therefore requires disciplined comparison of benefits, harms, probabilities, affected groups, duration and reversibility instead of moral absolutism or political slogan.

A hydroelectric project may provide clean energy and employment while displacing a tribal community and damaging ecology. Millian reasoning compares aggregate welfare, but Rawls asks whether the design protects and benefits the least advantaged. Kant prevents the displaced from being treated merely as compensable costs, while Aristotle requires proportionate, context-sensitive implementation.

The quotation does not mean that every right can be traded for a larger numerical gain. Constitutional rights, informed consent, rehabilitation and environmental limits remain ethical floors. The practical lesson is to choose the least harmful feasible option through evidence, consultation and transparent reasons, then monitor consequences and revise policy when the balance changes.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 - 10 marks

Question: "An unexamined life is not worth living." - Socrates. What does this quotation mean to you? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact official text: 2019 GS-IV Q6(a), local paper books/more_previous_papers/QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf. Cite the textual source as Plato, Apology 38a: Socrates as portrayed by Plato. Socrates left no writings; do not present the line as a Socrates-authored text. Isolated subpart: 10 marks, 150 words.

Model solution

The quotation makes reflective scrutiny central to a worthwhile moral life. Examination means identifying one's assumptions, asking whether reasons are consistent, inviting challenge and correcting conduct when evidence exposes bias. For a civil servant, it converts conscience from a private feeling into accountable reason-giving.

A district magistrate who initially attributes school absenteeism to parental indifference should test that belief through field visits. If transport, unsafe routes and seasonal work explain the pattern, self-examination requires policy revision rather than defensive persistence. The same discipline applies to conflicts of interest, prejudice in recruitment and habitual deference to senior orders.

Introspection alone is insufficient because people can rationalise self-interest. Peer review, recorded reasons, transparency and citizen consultation provide external correction. Textually, the line should be cited as Socrates speaking in Plato's Apology 38a, since Socrates wrote nothing. Its present administrative meaning is continuous ethical learning before and after exercising power.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2020 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish between laws and rules. Discuss the role of ethics in formulating them. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact official text: 2020 GS-IV Q4(a), local paper books/more_previous_papers/Gen_St_P4.pdf. Primary routing is Topic 10; included here because it directly supports Kant's legal-ethical distinction. This is one isolated 10-mark, 150-word subpart.

Model solution

Laws are publicly enacted, generally binding norms backed by state authority and formal sanctions. Rules are more specific operational prescriptions framed under law or within institutions to guide recurring conduct. Both regulate external behaviour, but legality alone does not establish moral legitimacy.

Ethics shapes their purpose, content and procedure. Dignity prevents a welfare rule from humiliating beneficiaries; equality rejects discriminatory eligibility; proportionality limits excessive penalties; transparency and participation make rule-making accountable. Kant's distinction is useful: law can demand outward compliance, while ethics asks whether the underlying maxim respects persons and could be universally justified.

For example, a lawful biometric rule may still be unethical if it excludes elderly citizens without alternatives. Ethics would require exception channels, data protection and grievance redress. Conversely, ethical aspirations require clear rules to avoid arbitrary discretion. Good governance therefore joins lawful authority with ethically defensible objectives, fair procedures and periodic review of actual consequences.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020 - 10 marks

Question: "A system of morality which is based on relative emotional values is a mere illusion, a thoroughly vulgar conception which has nothing sound in it and nothing true." - Socrates. What does this quotation mean to you? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact official text: 2020 GS-IV Q6(c), local paper books/more_previous_papers/Gen_St_P4.pdf. No matching sentence was identified in the searched classical Platonic, Xenophontic or academic sources. Treat it as 'attributed to Socrates in the paper,' not as a verified primary quotation. Isolated subpart: 10 marks, 150 words.

Model solution

The quotation warns that volatile feeling, personal preference or group sentiment cannot by themselves provide a stable moral standard. Public decisions need reasons that can be examined for consistency, factual accuracy, impartiality and generalisability. Otherwise prejudice may be relabelled as sincere emotion.

A district administration should not prohibit an inter-community marriage merely because a local majority feels offended. Mill distinguishes offence from harm, while Kant asks whether the discriminatory maxim could be universalised. Socratic questioning exposes whether the asserted value survives rational scrutiny.

The statement should not be read as making emotion ethically worthless. Empathy reveals suffering, remorse can motivate correction and compassion improves implementation. Emotion supplies morally relevant information, but reason and public justification must evaluate it. Provenance also requires caution: the exact sentence has not been located in classical sources. A responsible answer should therefore discuss the idea 'as attributed by the paper' rather than inventing a Platonic dialogue or page reference.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 - 10 marks

Question: "We can never obtain peace in the outer world until and unless we obtain peace within ourselves." - Dalai Lama. What does this quotation mean to you? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact official text: 2021 GS-IV Q3(b), local paper books/more_previous_papers/QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-IV-110122.pdf. The sentiment is widely attributed to the Dalai Lama, but the exact UPSC wording was not traced to a verified primary book, speech or transcript. Isolated subpart: 10 marks, 150 words.

Model solution

The quotation links external peace with internal emotional regulation. A person dominated by anger, fear, ego or prejudice carries those conflicts into public relationships; self-awareness and composure create the psychological space needed for listening, impartiality and non-violent problem-solving.

For a district magistrate mediating communal tension, inner peace means recognising personal anxiety, resisting retaliatory language, hearing each community and communicating calmly under pressure. It improves credibility and prevents the official from escalating the conflict through impulsive action. Aristotle would describe this as habituated temperance supported by practical wisdom.

Yet internal calm is only a precondition. Peace also requires justice, protection of rights, action against offenders and correction of structural grievances. Composure without substantive remedy can preserve an unjust status quo. The provenance should likewise be stated carefully: the exact wording is widely attributed but no primary source was verified. The administrative lesson is self-mastery joined with fair institutional action.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2021 - 10 marks

Question: "Life doesn't make any sense without interdependence. We need each other, and the sooner we learn that, it is better for us all." - Erik Erikson. What does this quotation mean to you? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact official text: 2021 GS-IV Q3(c), local paper books/more_previous_papers/QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-IV-110122.pdf. The canonical owner and routing ledger incorrectly render this as 'learning and acceptance'; the actual demand is interdependence and mutual need. No primary Erikson source for the exact sentence was verified. Isolated subpart: 10 marks, 150 words.

Model solution

The quotation rejects the fiction that individuals or institutions flourish in isolation. Human development depends on relationships of care, recognition, cooperation and reciprocal responsibility. In administration, interdependence means that authority, expertise and implementation are distributed across citizens, departments and levels of government.

Disaster relief illustrates this clearly. A district collector needs local communities for information, health workers for triage, police for access, civil society for last-mile support and neighbouring districts for logistics. Treating beneficiaries merely as passive recipients wastes local knowledge and weakens trust. Cooperative federalism and participatory governance are institutional expressions of the same insight.

Interdependence does not erase personal accountability; each actor remains responsible for assigned duties. Nor should the answer be diverted into 'learning and acceptance,' which is not the printed quotation. Since the exact sentence has not been traced to a primary Erikson text, it should be described as paper-attributed while its relational ethical meaning is analysed.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2022 - 10 marks

Question: "Ethics is knowing the difference between what you have the right to do and what is right to do." - Potter Stewart. What does this quotation mean to you? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact official text: 2022 GS-IV Q3(a), local paper books/more_previous_papers/QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER IV-190922.pdf. Primary routing is Topic 02; included for the legal-ethical gap. No primary judicial opinion, speech or writing by Potter Stewart containing the exact line was verified. Isolated subpart: 10 marks, 150 words.

Model solution

The quotation distinguishes legal permission from ethical justification. Rights protect a legitimate sphere of choice, but exercising a right can still be selfish, disproportionate or contrary to the responsibilities attached to public office. Ethics asks what ought to be done, not merely what sanctions can be avoided.

A senior official may have formal discretion to choose among eligible project sites, yet selecting land near a relative's business violates impartiality even before a specific anti-corruption offence is proved. Similarly, an authority may legally withhold optional information but should disclose it when citizens need it to protect health or livelihood. Kant's humanity formula and the fiduciary nature of public office explain the higher standard.

Ethics cannot, however, authorise officials to ignore law according to personal preference. Constitutional values, recorded reasons and review must discipline the judgment. The sentence is widely attributed to Potter Stewart, but no primary source was verified; answer the proposition without inventing a case citation.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2022 - 10 marks

Question: "Judge your success by what you had to give up in order to get it." - Dalai Lama. What does this quotation mean to you? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact official text: 2022 GS-IV Q3(c), local paper books/more_previous_papers/QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER IV-190922.pdf. Primary routing is Topic 02. The line circulated within the falsely attributed Dalai Lama 'Instructions for Life' chain-email tradition; no verified primary Dalai Lama source was identified. Isolated subpart: 10 marks, 150 words.

Model solution

The quotation proposes an ethical rather than merely numerical measure of success. Achievement should be assessed not only by targets reached but also by the values, relationships, rights and long-term capacities preserved or sacrificed during the process.

A district may clear an infrastructure corridor before deadline by suppressing hearings, underpaying displaced families and intimidating dissent. The output indicator records success, but Kantian dignity, Rawlsian fairness and procedural justice reveal moral failure. Conversely, giving up personal comfort, popularity or promotion to defend lawful rehabilitation may enhance the ethical quality of the achievement.

Sacrifice itself is not automatically noble: surrendering health, family duties or public resources for vanity can be irresponsible. The relevant test is what was sacrificed, whose interests bore the cost and whether the sacrifice was necessary and proportionate. Attribution also needs caution: the saying is linked to a misattributed chain-email list, not a verified Dalai Lama text. Use it as a paper-attributed ethical proposition.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2024 - 10 marks

Question: "In law, a man is guilty when he violates the rights of others. In ethics, he is guilty if he only thinks of doing so." - Immanuel Kant. What does this quotation convey to you in the present context? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact official text: 2024 GS-IV Q3(c), local paper books/mains/05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf. Closely adapted from Kant, Lectures on Ethics, trans. Louis Infield (1930), section 'Innocence,' pp. 212-13: 'harboured the thought of doing it.' The edition reconstructs lectures from student notebooks; it is not a sentence from a Kant-published ethical treatise. Isolated subpart: 10 marks, 150 words.

Model solution

The quotation distinguishes the external threshold of legal liability from the deeper ethical appraisal of maxims, intentions and cultivated dispositions. Law normally requires an act, attempt or legally cognisable violation; ethics can condemn a settled intention even when circumstances prevent its execution.

An officer who resolves to favour a contractor has already abandoned impartiality although cancellation of the tender may prevent criminal loss. A code of ethics therefore addresses integrity, motive and conflict disclosure beyond the completed acts prohibited by a conduct code. This reflects Kant's broader distinction between acting from duty and merely conforming outwardly to duty.

The statement must not become a doctrine of guilt for intrusive or passing thoughts. Infield's reconstructed lecture says 'harboured the thought' and then discusses impure dispositions, implying endorsement or cultivation of wrongful intent. Provenance should also be precise: UPSC modernises a passage from student-note-based Lectures on Ethics, not the Groundwork. Ethical self-scrutiny supplements, but does not replace, legal due process.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: "The greatest discovery of my generation is that a human being can alter his life by altering his attitudes." - William James. What does this quotation convey to you in the present context? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact official text: 2025 GS-IV Q3(b), local paper books/mains/UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf. The exact sentence has not been traced to William James's works. Norman Vincent Peale's *The Power of Positive Thinking* (1952) was an important popularising source for the James attribution. Treat it as paper-attributed. Isolated subpart: 10 marks, 150 words.

Model solution

The quotation emphasises that attitude influences perception, persistence and the range of possibilities a person is prepared to attempt. A constructive attitude does not deny difficulty; it converts setbacks into information, preserves agency and supports ethical action under pressure.

A newly posted officer facing entrenched malnutrition can either treat failure as proof that change is impossible or adopt a learning orientation: consult frontline workers, revise delivery timings, track exclusions and build cooperation. The changed attitude alters behaviour and can therefore alter institutional outcomes. Socratic examination prevents optimism from becoming self-deception, while Aristotelian habituation turns the orientation into stable practice.

Attitude alone cannot remove poverty, discrimination, inadequate budgets or structural incentives. Positive-thinking rhetoric becomes unjust when it blames victims for conditions beyond their control. Personal agency must be paired with institutional reform and material support. The exact wording is also unverified in James's corpus and was popularised through later self-help literature; answer it as attributed by UPSC rather than fabricating a James citation.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Explain the ethical significance of Kant's distinction between legal guilt and ethical guilt for contemporary public administration. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Kant's distinction shows that legality is an ethical floor, not the complete measure of public integrity. Law ordinarily addresses externally manifested acts, attempts and violations proved through due process. Ethical evaluation also asks what maxim, motive and cultivated disposition guided the official.

An officer who intends to favour a contractor but is prevented by cancellation may escape criminal liability, yet has abandoned impartiality and the good will. This explains why codes of ethics require conflict disclosure, objectivity and public-service commitment beyond the completed acts prohibited by conduct rules.

The 2024 UPSC wording needs a careful limit. Infield's 1930 *Lectures on Ethics*, reconstructed from student notebooks, refers to harbouring a wrongful thought and impure disposition, not involuntary mental events. Ethics should promote self-scrutiny and correction, not thought-policing. Thus ethical accountability supplements legal liability by addressing intention, while formal punishment must remain governed by law and evidence.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: How do Aristotle's Golden Mean and phronesis improve proportionality in administrative decision-making? Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

The Golden Mean identifies virtue between the vices of excess and deficiency, while phronesis is the practical wisdom needed to locate that mean in a particular case. The mean is relative to circumstances, not an arithmetic compromise.

In crowd control, excessive force shows rashness and complete inaction may show cowardice or neglect. A practically wise magistrate assesses intelligence, crowd behaviour, vulnerable persons and available alternatives, then chooses targeted restrictions and minimum necessary force. Repeated training and reflection turn such judgment into stable professional virtue.

Aristotle does not imply that every act has a moderate version: bribery or torture cannot become virtuous by reducing their amount. Nor may phronesis become unreviewable personal intuition. Constitutional rights, statutory limits, evidence and recorded reasons supply external discipline. Together, the Mean and phronesis make proportionality a character-informed, context-sensitive judgment bounded by law rather than a mechanical midpoint.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Can Mill's harm principle provide an adequate ethical constraint on utilitarian public policy? Discuss with suitable Indian administrative examples. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Utilitarian policy seeks the greatest aggregate welfare, but aggregation can sacrifice minorities when their losses are outweighed numerically. Mill's harm principle supplies a liberal constraint: coercion of a competent adult is justified principally to prevent harm to others, not merely offence, moral dislike or paternalistic majority preference.

During an epidemic, isolation of an infectious person can be justified because conduct risks harm to others. A blanket system of permanent location surveillance for all citizens, however, must show necessity, effectiveness and absence of less restrictive alternatives. Similarly, offensive but peaceful expression should not be prohibited merely because a majority disapproves. The burden of proof rests on coercion.

The principle is not fully adequate. Many actions create indirect spillovers, and the meaning, probability and threshold of harm are disputed. Mill also framed its scope around competent adults, requiring separate protection for children and persons lacking capacity. Rule-utilitarian support for due process and stable rights strengthens the constraint because arbitrary coercion damages long-term trust.

Therefore the harm principle is a strong presumption for liberty, not a complete algorithm. Indian administration should combine demonstrable harm, proportionality, least-restrictive means, rights review and periodic reassessment before coercing.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Apply Rawls's lexical priorities to evaluate the design of a targeted welfare scheme in India. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Rawls evaluates the basic structure through principles chosen in an original position where parties do not know their class, identity, talents or eventual social position. A welfare scheme should therefore be designed as if its authors might become its most vulnerable applicants.

First, equal basic liberties have lexical priority. Benefits cannot be conditioned on surrendering association, expression, privacy or due process merely to improve delivery efficiency. Second, fair equality of opportunity requires genuine access, not only formally identical eligibility. Online-only applications, inaccessible centres or documents unavailable to migrant workers defeat fair opportunity even when the rules appear neutral.

Only after these conditions does the difference principle operate. Targeting, administrative inequality or additional expenditure is justified when it materially improves the position of the least advantaged. Doorstep authentication for elderly persons or higher delivery costs in remote tribal areas can therefore be fair.

The veil remains a heuristic, not a literal policymaking procedure, and real design still requires data, fiscal feasibility and grievance evidence. A Rawlsian scheme protects liberties, equalises meaningful access and places the justificatory burden on exclusions and inequalities.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: A large infrastructure project promises substantial public benefits but will displace a small tribal community. Evaluate the decision through Kant, Mill, Aristotle and Rawls, and give a reasoned administrative verdict. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

The project creates a genuine conflict between aggregate development and the rights of a concentrated vulnerable group. A complete decision should test the act, consequences, administrative character and underlying institutional rule.

Mill asks whether long-term electricity, employment and connectivity benefits exceed ecological, cultural and livelihood harms. The calculation must include distribution, probability and irreversible loss, not only total monetary value. His harm principle also places the burden on coercive displacement and requires less restrictive alternatives.

Kant prohibits treating the community merely as an instrument for benefits enjoyed elsewhere. Full information, meaningful consultation, consent where legally required, fair rehabilitation and respect for cultural agency are dignity-based constraints, not costs that disappear inside a net-benefit figure.

Aristotle's phronesis rejects both automatic project cancellation and development at any price. A prudent administrator examines alternative alignments, project scale, ecological evidence, timing and proportionate mitigation. Courage may be needed to resist both populist obstruction and powerful commercial pressure.

Rawls asks whether the project rule would be accepted without knowing whether one would be an urban beneficiary or a displaced tribal resident. Inequality is defensible only if the least advantaged are genuinely benefited, with fair opportunity and basic liberties already protected.

The verdict is conditional approval only after independent alternatives assessment, rights-compliant consultation, livelihood-plus-cultural rehabilitation, benefit sharing, transparent monitoring and accessible appeal. If serious irreversible harm cannot be mitigated, the project should be redesigned or rejected.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: Philosophically audit India's contemporary AI-governance framework through Kant, Mill, Rawls, Aristotle and Socrates. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

India's AI Governance Guidelines identify seven technology-agnostic sutras: Trust, People First, Innovation over Restraint, Fairness and Equity, Accountability, Understandable by Design, and Safety, Resilience and Sustainability. Their recommendations span enablement, regulation and oversight. A February 2026 PIB brief presents M.A.N.A.V. as Moral and Ethical Systems, Accountable Governance, National Sovereignty, Accessible and Inclusive AI, and Valid and Legitimate Systems, framing AI around human aspirations, ethics and dignity.

The following philosopher-links are analytical inferences, not official classifications. Kant supports People First: automated decisions must respect persons as ends, preserve human agency and permit challenge rather than using citizens merely as data points. Rawls illuminates Fairness and Equity: training data, access and welfare algorithms should be tested from the standpoint of those most vulnerable to exclusion.

Mill links innovation to harm prevention. Regulation should address demonstrable risk while avoiding blanket restraint, and use proportionate, least-restrictive safeguards. Aristotle's phronesis supports risk-sensitive governance rather than one rigid rule across health, education and entertainment. Socratic examination supports Understandable by Design, reason-giving, contestability and continuous testing of assumptions.

The framework's ethical strength will depend on implementation: assigned accountability, accessible explanations, grievance redress, human oversight, bias testing and evidence of inclusion. Principles alone do not prove ethical outcomes. The appropriate verdict is innovation under human dignity, fairness, demonstrable safety and publicly reviewable reasons. Independent audit and effective remedies are necessary when automated decisions deny public benefits or reproduce exclusion.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.